

Getting an Accurate Heart Valve Diagnosis

You'll need a careful evaluation to decide on the best treatment.

Several tests can provide information about your heart valves and your circulation. Those tests are described in this section as they relate to valve disease.

Diagnostic checks in your health care professional's office

Your health care team will use diagnostic criteria to assess your needs and determine the severity of problems you might be having. The first diagnostic measure is usually auscultation, which is listening to your heart and any unusual sounds or [murmurs](#) with a stethoscope. Sometimes, you may be asked to change your position or bear down with your abdominal muscles to see if the murmur changes.

Learn more about further diagnostic testing

The remainder of this section covers what happens beyond listening to your heart in the office. [Echocardiography](#) is the main diagnostic tool for valve problems. Sometimes, the echocardiogram (echo) will provide all the needed information to decide on a treatment plan or to rule out the need for further treatment.

Sometimes, the information from the echo alone doesn't provide all the information. You may need [further testing](#) including an exercise test, chest X-rays, CT scan and sometimes cardiac catheterization.

Before seeing your health care professional or consulting a specialist about a possible heart valve problem, you have probably been told you have a [murmur](#) that needs to be checked or you may have experienced a physical [symptom or group of symptoms](#) that need further investigating.

Heart valve problems and abnormalities, whether because of [stenosis](#) or [regurgitation](#), often produce a heart murmur. A heart murmur can be harmless, known as an [innocent murmur](#), but many heart murmurs will need further investigation by your health care professional.

There are several methods for diagnosing heart valve disease. The most important is the [echocardiogram](#).

To assess your needs and determine the severity of problems you might be having, your health care team will use the following criteria:

- Whether or not you are having [symptoms](#) of valve problems
- Whether you have any other [heart conditions](#) to consider
- Appearance of the heart and valves
- Tightness or looseness of the valve opening
- Amount and pressure of the blood flowing properly through the valve
- Pressure and noted changes to the nearby tissues and organs

To fully understand your heart valve problem, your medical team may want to perform a series of tests to provide a complete picture of what needs repair and what may be best left alone.

1. **Appearance:** Some tests help to provide a picture of what the valve looks like.
 - Chest X-ray
 - Cardiac computed tomography
2. **Function:** Other tests help to determine how well the valve is able to do its job.
3. **Damage or Strain:** Still others help to evaluate the entire heart and nearby circulatory organs to see if your valve problem has affected your heart in ways that could place you at increased risk.
 - Exercise test
 - [Electrocardiogram](#)
 - Echocardiogram

Heart Valve Disease Resources

- [What is Heart Valve Disease? \(PDF\).](#)
- [Understanding Heart Valve Disease \(PDF\).](#)
- [Symptom Tracker \(PDF\).](#)
- [HVD Discussion Guide \(PDF\).](#)
- [After HVD Diagnosis Discussion Guide \(PDF\).](#)

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[Heart Valve Disease](#)



Heart Valves and Circulation

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Risks and Diagnosis



Getting an Accurate Diagnosis



Testing for Heart Valve Problems

Treatment Options



Recovery and Healthy Living Goals



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[Understanding Heart Valve Treatment Options](#)

PATIENT/DOCTOR

Discussion Guide

Be prepared to get the most out of your appointment.



Learn as much as you can about your condition.



Write down questions to ask your health care professional.

Aortic stenosis is a common condition where the aortic valve in the heart narrows, often due to aging, making it harder for blood to flow.

The hardened valve opening restricts blood flow from the heart to the rest of the body, including the coronary arteries. This can lead to symptoms such as fatigue, dizziness, shortness of breath and chest pain.

Untreated, symptoms can worsen, leading to heart failure and possibly death.



It's important to seek treatment as soon as possible

There is no cure for aortic stenosis. But you can manage early symptoms with medication and a healthy lifestyle.

When the symptoms become severe or your heart function declines, your health care professional may recommend replacing the damaged valve.

At your appointment:

[Your Aortic Stenosis Care Team](#)